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ASEAN's inheritance: the regionalization of Southeast Asia, 1941–61

Philip Charrier

Abstract This article explores the establishment of Southeast Asia as a regional space in the international system before the advent of ASEAN. It challenges the traditional view that the region emerged from Japanese and Allied strategies and operations during the Second World War, focusing instead upon the important role played by academics in the creation of 'Southeast Asian studies' in the United States and Britain in the 1940s and 1950s. On a broader level, the article highlights the cyclical nature of the regionalization process. It suggests that once a region has been 'created', the repeated use of the regional idea by a variety of state and non-state actors fixes it in a broad cultural context, and opens the way for subsequent appropriation by regionalizers.

Keywords Southeast Asia; ASEAN; region; regionalization; space; spatial.

Introduction

On April 30, 1999, The Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) today admitted Cambodia as its tenth member fulfilling its vision to establish an organization for all Southeast Asian countries. . . . With Cambodia's entry, the ASEAN region now has a total

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> population of about 500 million, a total area of 4.5 million square kilometers, a combined gross national product of US$685 billion, and a total trade of US$720 billion.
>
> (ASEAN 2000b)

ASEAN is one of the most successful and enduring regional associations of the contemporary period and has served as a case study for understanding the 'new regionalism', which has become an important feature of international relations in recent decades. ASEAN is generally studied in the context of the security, and more recently, economic, issues that engage its member countries. However, the nature of ASEAN's *spatial* presence in the global environment also merits attention. Successful regionalist initiatives depend as much upon the creation of meaningful collective spatial identities, which transcend those of the individual member countries, as they do upon the establishment of common cultural, economic and political bases of interaction. These identities are often complex, based upon widely differing combinations of historical, cultural and geographical features.

The addition of Vietnam, Laos, Myanmar and Cambodia to the ASEAN fold between 1995 and 1999 allowed the association to realize 'the vision of ASEAN-10 (having all 10 countries in Southeast Asia in ASEAN)' (ASEAN 2000b). This 'vision' is said to have grown out of the Bangkok Declaration of August 1967, which stated 'that the Association is open for participation to all States in the South-East Asian Region' (ASEAN 2000c). There can be little doubt that considerations of a more practical nature than the achievement of a spatial 'vision' contributed to ASEAN's hazardous drive to enlarge its membership in the last years of the twentieth century (Kraft 2000: 454–7). Nevertheless, the attraction of achieving the perfect alignment of 'region' and 'regional organization' seems to have had an importance that was more than just metaphorical or symbolic. How did the notion of such a Southeast Asian spatial identity arise, and at what point did it come to be seen as consisting of specifically ten separate, independent nation-states?

New regions like ASEAN have been described as 'fluid and variable' entities, whose boundaries and constituent peoples are infinitely variable and ultimately a matter of political negotiation' (Grugel and Hout 1999: 9; Hoogvelt 1997: 217). Such negotiation is carried out by states and dominant state and non-state actors as part of regionalist projects to reorganize the political and economic relations in a certain area (Cox 1981: 126–55; Hout 1999: 22–4; Gamble and Payne 1996: 250).[1] It will be argued here that far from creating a 'new' space on the basis of political and geographical commonalities among its member states, ASEAN occupied and indigenized an existing one, which after 1941 became not only an established *geographical* sub-region of the world, but a widely-recognized *political* unit of the international system. The organization subsequently superimposed its vision of a particular kind of regional identity upon this space to suit its

own needs and interests, just as an earlier generation of political actors in Southeast Asian countries based their nationalist political projects upon colonial spaces which had been carved out of the Asian continent by Britain, France, Spain and the Netherlands in the preceding centuries.

Amitav Acharya has recently argued that the modern collective Southeast Asian identity now associated with ASEAN has indigenous roots which predate the colonial and early postcolonial periods of the region's history (Acharya 1999, 2000). This article does not seek to challenge the evidence that during their long, pre-modern history, complex political, economic and social ties did at times connect many of the lands of southeastern Asia. However it puts forward that as a specific, widely recognized geopolitical 'space' in the contemporary world system, the regional entity 'Southeast Asia' originated not from local patterns of interaction or the activities of indigenous actors, but rather – as Antaya and Fifield have argued – from the regionalizing activities of 'outsiders' (Antaya 1997: 135; Fifield 1984: 128). The process by which Southeast Asia became such a 'space' (i.e. how it was first regionalized) is the principal concern of this article.

The subject material will be explored on the basis of the three organizational concepts: (a) the establishment of encircling physical *boundaries*, which gave the regional unit geographical meaning; (b) the identification of social, economic and political *connections* between the countries involved, which created a sense of shared identity and set the region apart from the countries and peoples that lay outside it;[2] and (c) the *recurrence* of the concept of the region over time in a cultural context, both within the region and beyond it, in such a way that it became an established element of popular discourse.

In a famous essay first published in 1928, the historian Lucien Febvre asserted that no natural frontiers exist between countries, only the memory of man-made ones concretized by the forces of history. Febvre argued that the widely acknowledged physical boundaries of France do not constitute 'natural frontiers' but rather 'historical frontiers' which date back to the Roman conquest and colonization of Europe. Febvre did not view such frontiers as permanently fixed in historical time, but nevertheless argued that once created they were surprisingly durable (Febvre 1973).

By extending this line of argument from 'countries' to 'regions', it is possible to suggest that the recurrence of the idea of a region in popular culture functions to give it the kind of rigidity which Febvre discussed with reference to the frontiers of France (Febvre 1973: 215; Sahlins 1989: 276). Thus regional spaces develop an increasingly durable identity over time by the very fact of being repeatedly recognized as such in contemporary culture. As will be shown, once created these spaces can be used and re-used in regional projects of various kinds. Repeated usage of the regional idea by a wide assortment of actors and organizations, for a variety of purposes, further strengthens that idea as the basis for new projects.

Southeast Asia: real or imagined space?

Soldiers and politicians, activated by war and the pursuit of national interests, have been credited with discovering the Southeast Asian region. Donald Emmerson has argued that 'warfare not scholarship made [the word] "Southeast Asia" popular'. He was referring to the Pacific War and Japan's role in 'destroying the colonial distinctions' between the various territories in the region, and as such activating 'the long process whereby Western politicians were forced to recognize the [Southeast Asian] forest, as a whole and in its own right, and to specify its borders'. Emmerson says that before 1942, 'Western statesmen felt little incentive to standardize the boundaries of the term, for it was esoteric', and that the few Western scholars who had used the term 'did not justify its use on grounds of distinctive content, for it was overshadowed in their minds by impressions of India and China' (Emmerson 1984: 7). Pekka Korhonen has argued that the war made the previously obscure 'metaphor' Southeast Asia into 'an everyday word' (Korhonen 1997: 356).

Russell Fifield and Tim Huxley have similarly made reference to the 'conceptualization' of Southeast Asia that took place during and after the Second World War. For Huxley it was the region's increasing strategic importance to rival powers that gave meaning to the concept (Huxley 1996: 203–4), while Fifield states that 'political perceptions of the area as a region' developed from Southeast Asia's new strategic and political importance in international relations (Fifield 1975: 42; 1992: 20).

By looking beneath the 'action' of the Second World War and at the roles played by such unlikely regionalists as J. S. Furnivall, Rupert Emerson, Lennox A. Mills, Virginia Thompson, Bruno Lasker and several other pioneering academics in the nascent field of Southeast Asian studies, it is possible to propose an alternative explanation for the regionalization of Southeast Asia. Accordingly, a small group of academics whose fieldwork prior to the war included parts of what subsequently came to be known as the region of Southeast Asia, responded to an opportunity to develop and categorize their work in a new way. By collectively defining a new space in the international system which incorporated the various elements of their research, they created a mechanism for giving additional meaning to their work, and also of publicizing it in such a way that it became more important and visible. Furthermore, by giving that space academic recognition, they laid the groundwork for it to become known and accepted on a much broader level.[3]

As it happened, this academic effort coincided with a succession of great movements and events (anti-colonialism, the Second World War, decolonization, the Cold War) that involved soldiers and politicians in developments in the part of the world now regarded as Southeast Asia. Whether the space would have been defined in this specific way without the concurrence of such historical events and the Japanese, British and American

practitioners who helped to shape them is open to question; whether Southeast Asia would have been created without a conscious academic effort to bring it into being seems unlikely.

According to the 'alternative' scenario proposed here, Southeast Asia can be seen to have emerged after 1941 as a new 'space' for academic concentration as part of an Anglo-American movement which established 'area studies' as a legitimate and important field of academic endeavour. From the beginning, Southeast Asian studies was rooted squarely in the social scientific tradition and offered a compelling new means for exploring historical, ethnic, geographical, economic and political information about places on the globe that suddenly seemed to matter in world affairs (Quigley 1951: 500–6; Wood 1968: 401–7; Ward 1973: 391–403). However, as the reality of Southeast Asia did not yet exist (in the sense that it was not widely accepted, or even recognized, as a separate geographical or political entity), the commitment to the area-focused approach served primarily as the vision of the 'area' still to be created or filled in.

The process by which Southeast Asia became a distinct region in the international system can be argued to have begun with the publication of J. S. Furnivall's now largely forgotten monograph *Progress and Welfare in Southeast Asia* in 1941. While not the first book to use the term 'Southeast Asia' in its title, or to treat the region as a separate and discrete region in Asia, it was the first to interpret it as a 'space' of political significance in its own right. This is important, because, as will be shown, while a common identity on the basis of physical, ethnic, religious or historical factors was difficult to establish, on political and economic grounds it was not. Furnivall's book was the first in a series of six 'research reports' on Southeast Asia published by the Institute of Pacific Relations in 1941 and 1942.[4] Within the next two decades, during which time the strategic importance of Southeast Asia was highlighted in both the Pacific War and the Cold War, more than one hundred books and articles were published on Southeast Asia, *the region*. Most of these dealt with contemporary political and economic issues, and virtually all were written by Western scholars. Academic initiatives intersected with political forces to make, fill and shape a region that had previously been on the margins of modern history. During the 1940s and 1950s, the process that created Southeast Asia was undertaken primarily by individuals and interests external to the region. Only after the creation of the Federation of Malaya in 1957 did some indigenous political actors undertake 'serious initiatives' to claim the space for their own purposes and 'develop regional associations with an essentially Southeast Asian scope and character' (Acharya 2000: 74). In 1961 the Philippines, Thailand and Malaya joined to form the Association of South East Asia (ASA). Six years later, following ASA's dissolution, ASEAN was founded by Indonesia, Malaysia, the Philippines, Singapore and Thailand.

Boundaries

> . . . a division of the world into regions . . . is no more than a classification of places, each place considered independently of others. It is a classification table put on a map, which enables us . . . to describe approximately the character of certain features of a large number of places simultaneously.
>
> (Hartshorne 1959: 132)

That Southeast Asia does not 'exist' objectively as a distinct geographical entity of the Asian landmass is evident by looking at the difficult process by which its boundaries came gradually to be established. Between 1941 and 1961 a variety of overlapping grids or 'classification tables' were used to delimit the part of Asia between India and China that during the nineteenth century had been a region of intense imperial competition between Britain, France and the Netherlands; that Japan had occupied between 1942 and 1945; and that subsequently experienced several decades of dramatic and often violent political unrest. Some geographers and political scientists applied the concept of Southeast Asia in an expansive way so that it included all or parts of India, China, Korea and Japan.[5] However, the concept usually referred to Burma, Malaya, Singapore, Thailand, Indochina, Indonesia and the Philippines – i.e. the region between India, China and Australasia. The Austrian-born anthropologist Robert Heine-Geldern, who is widely regarded as the founder of Southeast Asian studies, defined it as such in 1943 (Heine-Geldern 1943).[6] This is also the way the pioneering Asian studies journal *The Far Eastern Quarterly* (*FEQ*)[7] came to frame the region. Between its establishment in November 1941 and the publication of Volume 3, Number 2, in February 1944, the journal's 'Far Eastern Bibliography' grouped the countries of the region in two sections: 'Indo-China, Thailand, Burma, Malaya', on the one hand, and 'The Philippines and the East Indies', on the other. The term Southeast Asia was not used. From Volume 3, Number 3 (May 1944), the two sections were grouped together under the new, descriptive, heading 'Southeastern Asia'. This was replaced by the prescriptive classification 'Southeast Asia' in Volume 4, Number 3 (May 1945), a classification which was used thereafter without modification.[8]

However, articles published in the *FEQ* during the 1940s and 1950s, as well as books reviewed by the journal, utilized slightly different definitions, and in fact 'understood' the region in a variety of ways. Some scholars took a broad approach to the concept, squeezing such territories as Ceylon and Formosa into the space (Hall 1947; Emerson *et al.* 1942), while others took a narrower one, cutting out the Philippines and/or Burma (Landon 1943; Hall 1955).[9]

The uncertain and overlapping quality of this scholarly work was in part the result of the practical geographic problem that the massive Asian

continent could not easily be broken down into neat sub-areas.[10] This was evident by the obvious difficulty with which Amry Vandenbosch tried in 1946 to give logical physical boundaries to the region:

> Mountains and highlands separate [Southeast Asia] . . . from India and China. The Malay Peninsula, Sumatra, Java and the Lesser Sunda Islands form the Malay Barrier, separating the Indian and Pacific Oceans and forming a number of seas and gulfs within the heart of the region. The Philippine Islands clearly form a part of the Malay Archipelago, but where to draw the line in the southeast is somewhat of a problem. The New Guinea group does not normally belong to this region, but the whole of Netherlands Indies is generally included . . . chiefly no doubt because of the convenience of including entire political and administrative units. But if Dutch New Guinea is included, there is little reason for excluding Australian New Guinea and the adjacent islands to the East.

Vandenbosch concluded, obviously somewhat dissatisfied with this unwieldy definition, that 'no region ever has natural and logical boundaries on all sides' (Vandenbosch 1946: 427).

Four years later the geographer E. H. G. Dobby conceived the following more succinct definition: '[Southeast Asia consists of] those territories of Eastern Asia which lie south of the Tropic of Cancer (Burma, Siam, Indochina, Malaya) and the nearby islands spreading eastward from the Asiatic continent towards New Guinea' (Dobby 1950: 17). As with the earlier effort, however, it failed to provide a logical geographical rationale for the inclusion of only part of New Guinea. The search for well-defined historical, cultural and linguistic frontiers made the task of effectively sectioning off Southeast Asia from the rest of the continent no easier. The assimilation of Hindu–Buddhist traditions bound together many, but not all, of the peoples of the region (Heine-Geldern 1942; Coedes 1944). The experience of colonization was widespread, but not universal.[11] Even the region's demographic pattern was uneven (Zalinsky 1950).

The establishment of the Allied South-East Asia Command (SEAC) in 1943, while no doubt helping to forge an identity for the region distinct from the old, fragmented colonial one, was in fact somewhat misleading in that it was much more 'British colonial' than the name would suggest. Under the leadership of Admiral Lord Louis Mountbatten, SEAC was based in a British colony which was not located geographically in Southeast Asia (Ceylon) and was initially responsible for liberating two British colonies (Burma and Malaya), one British zone of influence (Thailand) and part of a Dutch colony which was adjacent to a British colony (Sumatra) (Thorne 1978: 300–1). The 'space' incorporating these places represented only a part of the region that was emerging in the scholarship as *geographical* Southeast Asia.[12] Furthermore, according to SEAC's

own outlook, Southeast Asia was defined negatively as a region from which Japan had to be expelled rather than one with any positive identity. Boundaries were military only (Mountbatten 1951).

This situation changed fundamentally with the Potsdam Conference of August 1945, when it was agreed that SEAC's boundaries would be extended into all of the lands that, coincidentally, the *FEQ* was by then defining as Southeast Asia, except Indochina below the 16th parallel, the Philippines, and Timor (Thorne 1978: 522–3). This brought the military 'space' much more into line with the academic one, and as such sharpened the geographical concept of the region (Emmerson 1984: 8; Fifield 1992: 21).

The most significant impact of the extension of SEAC's boundaries in 1945 was that it opened the way for Southeast Asia to begin to be seen as a zone of Asia with a common political profile. Between September 1945 and March 1946, SEAC came into conflict with the new nationalisms in Vietnam and Indonesia, confronting at least four separate political and/or religious groups in Vietnam and a broad spectrum of militarized Indonesian nationalists and malcontents (Marr 1980: 147–50; Reid 1981: 140–8; Dunn 1985; Dennis 1987). As a result, nationalism came to be seen as a 'force' in Southeast Asia rather than a patchwork of disturbances confined to minority groups within the various colonies. This situation made it apparent that much more than a simple geographical space, Southeast Asia was a political entity with significant shared features. The political turmoil gave the new space not just identity, but in Hartshorne's description quoted at the beginning of this section, 'character'. The components of this character are explored in the next section.

Connections

The geographer Yi-Fu Tuan has distinguished between the familiar 'spaces of daily life' (work, home, neighbourhood, farm, city) and everything else, which he identifies as 'space at large'. Activated by the need to order space that is not familiar, Tuan argues that people create explanatory structures which are then superimposed upon it. These structures function 'not simply as a reference system suited to the needs for orientation', but rather represent 'an effort to find value and meaning in the world and to locate them at definite places' (Tuan 1978: 9–10). If we consider 'Southeast Asia' as such a structure, then it is to be wondered by what process it came to be fashioned? As will be shown in this section, the process was an academic one at first, which involved the discovery of connections between peoples and histories contained in the space. Gradually a unifying approach to the study of the region emerged, giving the space an identity separate from the lands and peoples that lay outside and beyond it. By surveying some of the main academic publications on Southeast Asia from 1941 onwards, it is possible to see how the fuzzy area

which gradually came into focus as Southeast Asia became recognizable both in terms of shared internal characteristics (political, economic, ethnic, geographical) and common external experiences (colonialism).[13] The space was also historicized, so that a sense developed of the region's unified past (mainly from the point of view of 'civilization'), its present (colonialism, nationalism, underdevelopment), and its future (emancipation from colonial rule, development, democratization).

1941–45

The first generation of Southeast Asian specialists was preoccupied with the problem of colonialism in the region, and their work was oriented in large measure towards uncovering its ills and arguing the case for its termination. For these social scientists, Southeast Asia was at once a convenient unit for comparative work within their field of interest and a metaphor for a condition shared by virtually all the peoples of the 'region'. The difficulty that emerged as the idea of Southeast Asia was developed is that the region is in fact as diverse as it is uniform. This opened up a tension in the scholarship between the general and the specific which characterizes Southeast Asian studies to this day. Those academics who emerged as advocates of the regional idea had to devote considerable effort to demonstrate that it had some kind of logical basis.[14]

Some, like J. S. Furnivall and Kenneth Landon, considered Southeast Asia to be a region based upon their understanding of what it had been in the past – before the arrival of colonialism – rather than what it was in the 1940s. Furnivall asserted the existence of a traditional Southeast Asian 'social order', which was both consistent across the region, and of a unique character (Furnivall 1941: 4). The colonial powers had disrupted this order – mainly because of 'divergences' in their patterns of rule (Furnivall 1941: 5–47) – and it seemed unlikely to be re-established. Thus when Furnivall imagined the future of the region, it was as a collection of nation-states which had developed from the old colonies, 'often in contrary directions' (Furnivall 1941: 69), rather than as a re-integrated region.

Furnivall's Southeast Asia was created on the basis of a traditional/modern paradigm according to which an older but weaker civilization had come into conflict with a newer, more powerful one, with unfortunate results for the former. Landon similarly believed that the 'connections' which bound Southeast Asian peoples together derived from the traditional nature of their society, and the shared disruptive experience of colonialism (Landon 1943: 140–1). He was less pessimistic than Furnivall about the future, believing nationalism to be a positive force for change. But he did see Southeast Asian identity as being historical rather than modern.

In contrast, most of the social scientists who published work on Southeast Asia between 1941 and 1945 identified the region on the basis of

contemporary trends and future possibilities. This gave a fluidity and openness to the idea which was in marked contrast to that of the traditionalists. As such, the work of scholars like Virginia Thompson, Rupert Emerson, Bruno Lasker and Jan Broek was both positivist and prescriptive, seeing unity as a project which would allow Southeast Asian peoples to break free of the colonial past, modernize their economies and facilitate democratization. Ethnic, anthropological, religious and other 'traditional' elements were given relatively little attention in comparison with political and economic factors arising from the experience of colonialism, which were seen as the key links or connections between Southeast Asian peoples. For example, Thompson noted 'The striking similarity displayed by the nationalist movements throughout southeast Asia' (Emerson *et al.* 1942: 127), while for Emerson the identity of the region derived in large measure from the common economic backwardness of its inhabitants (Emerson *et al.* 1942: 26).[15] Nationalism and development are both future-oriented.

For his part, Lasker adopted a Marxist–reductionist perspective in his *Peoples of South-East Asia* (1944), concentrating upon defining and describing what he saw as the basic economic unit of the region – the Southeast Asian peasant. Lasker utilized 'occupation' as a means of categorizing Southeast Asian peoples into 'types': he thus distinguished between peasants, merchant farmers, craftsmen and artists, and tradesmen. His work was intended, at least in part, to counter the myth that Southeast Asian peoples were 'primitive' tribes people. He saw them instead as 'millions of hard working peasants' who were 'in a transitional stage between a backward-looking pre-industrial and a forward-looking technically equipped civilization' (Lasker 1944: 17, 183). By emphasizing the peasant as the basic building block or most obvious defining aspect of Southeast Asian society, and by describing him as being in a state 'of cultural ferment' (Lasker 1944: 13), Lasker can be seen to have prepared the ground for the post-war notion that the Southeast Asian peasantry had a vital role to play in the process of political change.

What is notable with respect to these future-oriented studies was the determination to identify connections and to highlight their importance, while at the same time acknowledging the existence of differences. For example, while Thompson, Emerson and Lasker distinguished between local differences, in the main they treated the region as a unit. Emerson wrote: 'To regard the territories of southeast Asia as forming a single unit is perhaps an error save in the sense that they have in common their status as Asiatic borderlands and as colonial or quasi-colonial appendages of the Powers' (Emerson *et al.* 1942: 3). But he went on to discuss the common political, economic and historical 'threads' that, he believed, 'imposed a certain similarity of destiny' (Emerson *et al.* 1942: 5). Jan Broek similarly saw Southeast Asia as being characterized far more by geographical and 'social' 'contrasts and divergent interests' than by commonalities. Nevertheless, he concluded that there were 'certain considerations of a

broader nature and of far-reaching significance that give validity to the concept' (Broek 1944: 189). These included achieving decolonization, improving access to raw materials, creating structures for economic development, and finding a means for locating the region's strategic position within some kind of broad, international arrangement (Broek 1944: 189–95).

These features were significant and meaningful connections during an era preoccupied in large measure with the shape of the post-Second World War world order. They gave Southeast Asia a clear identity as a socio-culturally similar, economically exploited, politically unstable region that would become an important area of change following the defeat of Japan.

1945–50

The suddenness and ferocity with which nationalist movements emerged across Southeast Asia in late 1945 to oppose the return of the European colonial powers gave a new urgency to the view that decolonization was the only way forward. In August 1945 Indonesian revolutionaries led by Sukarno and Mohammed Hatta proclaimed an independent Republic of Indonesia. The following month, after gaining control of the biggest cities in all three parts of Vietnam, Ho Chi Minh's Vietminh proclaimed an independent Democratic Republic of Vietnam. By early 1946 it was evident that these political movements had grown so strong during the war that the French and Dutch would not succeed in reimposing their authority without making significant concessions to the nationalists; that the Philippines would rapidly be decolonized; and that Burma would insist upon complete independence from Britain at the earliest possible date.

Many of the books and articles published between 1945 and 1950 analysed the rapid advances made by Southeast Asian nationalist groups during and after the Pacific War. While acknowledging the 'peculiarly complex . . . array of racial, cultural, linguistic, and religious groups' which characterized the different parts of the region (Emerson 1946: 212),[16] these publications further contributed to the pattern established during the war of emphasizing political and economic similarities across the region.[17]

Of particular influence on the scholarship of the early post-war years was the pioneering work carried out by Lasker, which, as we have seen, defined Southeast Asian identity on the basis of the political/economic profile of the approximately 180 million peasants who inhabited the region. Erich Jacoby, for example, studied the economic condition of this group and concluded that Southeast Asian peasants were preoccupied mainly with problems of land tenure, agricultural production, and the disruptive influence of rapid social and economic change (Jacoby 1949: 5–6). He considered the region's fundamental economic problem to be the exploitation of the peasants of the region by their landlords, who distributed the land inequitably, charged exorbitant rents, and often enforced their control using violent means. He believed the plight of Southeast Asia's peasants

to be the 'basis of the nationalist movement in all the countries of Southeast Asia', movements which adjusted themselves to it and whose propaganda 'use[d] and abuse[d] it' (Jacoby 1949: 170).

In a similar vein, Lasker's *Human Bondage in Southeast Asia* (1950) argued that there was a 'single fundamental factor' which appeared 'in all the countries of Southeast Asia', and that was the economic and political subjugation of the masses not just under colonial rule, but also under 'their own princes and privileged classes' (Lasker 1950: 4–5).

Firth likewise considered the general condition of the Southeast Asian peasant to be the main source of instability in the region. But rather than an unjust socio-economic structure, he believed Westernization to be the most important disruptive influence in the way that it had opened up a gap between the peasant's 'expanding range of wants and his level of productivity', on the one hand, and cut him off from any kind of control of 'the economic forces operating in his field', on the other (Firth 1950: 510).

By the late 1940s the deepening nature of the colonial crises in Vietnam and Indonesia, the emergence of a new one in Malaya, and the spread of the Cold War to the region led to interest in Southeast Asia and Southeast Asian affairs broadening out from its small and narrow academic enclave into the realm of government. One indication of this change was the appearance of Lennox Mills's *The New World of Southeast Asia*, which was not only the first general political and economic survey of the area as a whole, but also the first to explicitly link such an academic endeavour to the foreign policy interests of a particular government – in this case the United States (Mills and Associates 1949: v). In this context it is noteworthy that of the eight 'specialists' who contributed articles, two were State Department officials (John F. Cady and Kenneth P. Landon), two others former State Department officials (Claude A. Buss and Amry Vandenbosch), and another (Roland S. Vaile) a consultant to the US National Resources Commission.

In his introduction Mills described Southeast Asia as 'the forgotten zone of the [Asian] continent' and characterized its 'troubled state' primarily in the context of 'the [political] revolt of Asia against Western rule' (Mills and Associates 1949: 3, 9). The chapters of the book examined such issues as colonialism, nationalism, economic underdevelopment and communism with an urgency and sense of importance which implied that Southeast Asian problems could no longer be viewed as remote from those of the United States itself.

This message reflected a process of expansion within the US foreign policy establishment to incorporate Southeast Asia into its rapidly growing area of interest. In 1945 the United States Department of State renamed the 'Division of Southwest Pacific Affairs' the 'Division of Southeast Asian Affairs' to more accurately reflect its focus upon this new, volatile area (Fifield 1992: 22). In addition, funding was provided by the Carnegie Corporation to establish a Southeast Asia programme at Yale University

(1947) and by the Rockefeller Foundation to establish a similar programme at Cornell University (1950) (Fifield 1976: 154). In 1946 the East Indies Institute of America changed its name to Southeast Asia Institute and expanded its area of research to include the Philippines, Malaya, Burma, Siam and Indochina (*FEQ* 5: 219). Under the influence of the Cold War, considerations of security were paramount, and this encouraged the forging of an approach toward Southeast Asia which highlighted political and economic problems which were common across the region.

During the first years after 1945, however, the new South-East Asia Department of the British Foreign Office played the more active role in utilizing and promulgating the idea of a newly emerging and distinct Southeast Asian region. In March 1946, one month after Mountbatten's SEAC was wound up, the British created the new position of 'Special Commissioner in South-East Asia' to keep the regional idea alive. Lord Killearn was appointed to the position and made responsible for coordinating the economic recovery of Southeast Asia from the disruptions caused to local economies by the Second World War (Tarling 1986: 559–600). Two years later, following the disestablishment of this position, yet another successor to SEAC was created in the form of the new position of 'Commissioner-General for the United Kingdom in South-East Asia'. Under this title, Malcolm MacDonald was made responsible for coordinating British policy across the region spanning Burma, Thailand, French Indochina, Malaya, Indonesia and the Philippines. MacDonald played an important role in leading British anti-communist activities in the region, and also in constructing the Commonwealth's 'Colombo Plan for Cooperative Economic Development in South and South-East Asia' in 1951, a scheme that can be seen as yet a further offspring of the regional idea begun with the creation of SEAC in 1943 (Charrier 1995). The structures they instituted for effecting that policy represented involvement on a practical level of the 'new' Southeast Asia being constructed on the scholarly one. By becoming actively involved in the process of discovering connections between the various Southeast Asian countries, Britain gave additional meaning to that process.

Thus in the space of less than ten years Southeast Asia had developed from a new and recondite concept, to an established 'structure' which the American and British foreign policy establishments found useful in interpreting events in a relatively unknown and rapidly-changing part of the world. The next section will argue that, through the process of recurrence, Southeast Asia's spatial identity became further fixed in post-war international culture.

Recurrence

We have argued that the regionalization of Southeast Asia was pioneered by academic actors like Furnivall and Lasker, before gaining broader

legitimacy through such organizations as the Allied Southeast Asia Command and the Commonwealth's Colombo Plan. General boundaries were established as part of this process, and such common features as the experience of colonialism, the development of nationalist movements, and the condition of underdevelopment were emphasized between and amongst peoples that in some other respects were quite diverse. However, by 1958 the majority of the region's countries had gained independence,[18] reducing the relevance of the colonial past and anti-colonial nationalism as important connecting strands. Underdevelopment persisted; but by the mid-1960s Singapore, Malaysia, Thailand and Indonesia were showing impressive signs of economic growth.

This final section will examine how the Southeast Asian regional project was sustained during the period when many of the old political and economic connections diminished in importance. It will argue that once the idea of Southeast Asia as a distinct region in Asia had been created, what was important was no longer *the details* of the idea, but the fact of its recurrence. As long as the concept of Southeast Asia remained useful or convenient to highlight common features of the area, the nature of the relationship between the specific political and economic elements that actually constituted it mattered less than did the continued use of the concept itself.

E. Relph has noted that 'the persistence of the character of places' is connected 'to a continuity in both our experience of change and in the very nature of change that serves to reinforce a sense of association and attachment to those places' (Relph 1976: 31; Parkes and Thrift 1980: Ch. 1). The first part of this idea refers to the phenomenon of 'repetitive tradition', which Relph argues 'reestablishes place and expresses its stability and continuity' (Relph 1976: 32). When applied to Southeast Asia it suggests that repeated usage of the regional idea by various actors gave it continuity and stability; but also, that the experience of the idea in the broader cultural environment acted in an indirect way to concretize its meaning and importance. The second component of Relph's assertion is particularly interesting. It indicates that the very fact of the passage of time, a passive action which inherently signifies change, acts to reconfirm the existence of a place. As Relph explains, 'time is actually part of our experience of places, for these experiences must be bound up with flux and continuity' (Relph 1976: 33). Applying this principle to Southeast Asia, it follows that once the idea of the region had been created or imagined as a place in the international geographical landscape, with time it became more deeply embedded in the collective consciousness simply by the fact of remaining in existence.

In what follows, Relph's idea of how repetitive tradition and the passage of time reconfirms place will be combined in the more general one of 'recurrence', the assumption being that the recurrence of the concept of 'Southeast Asia' as a real 'space' helped to make that space more 'real'.

It will be argued that the emergence of the region as a major contested area in the Cold War is in large measure responsible for promulgating in a repetitive way the notion of its collective identity. But, as will be shown, the use of the concept by other groups and organizations assisted in this process.

1948–61

Within three years of the end of the war, the early post-war vision of a restless, energetic, integrating Southeast Asia was replaced by that of a vulnerable, yielding one. The image of the rising nationalist tide gave way to that of the unstable row of dominoes. The change came about because of a dramatic series of communist uprisings across Southeast Asia in 1948, the 'loss' of China to communism in 1949, and the steady deterioration of the French position in Vietnam, which culminated in the defeat at Dien Bien Phu in May 1954. The cumulative effect of all this communist activity was deeply alarming to British and American governments in that it suggested that some kind of central (i.e. Soviet) coordination was taking place. During the 1950s both London and Washington committed significant resources to fighting communism in the region. In addition, British troops were active in Malaya throughout the decade, and the United States began to provide substantial military aid to Vietnam in 1950 (Rotter 1987: 202). By the time ASA was established in 1961, the area had become a hotly contested Cold War zone.

The spread of the East–West confrontation to Asia ushered in a new period of great-power interference in Southeast Asian politics that twisted scholarly social scientific analysis into peculiar Cold War shapes. Bryce Wood has noted that 'The post-World War II expansion of the scope of foreign policy [in Western countries] into propaganda, education, and technical aid . . . created a demand for government personnel with specialized knowledge of foreign cultures and languages' (Wood 1968: 404). It also created a demand for useful information from area studies centres on which to base anti-communist activities. With respect to Southeast Asia, area specialists responded to increased government interest in 'their' area by concentrating on projects that were more closely tied to national foreign policy interests. Thus some British and American social scientists, who had previously concentrated upon local political structures and anti-colonial nationalism, began to look more specifically at communist movements and communist uprisings. For example, Virginia Thompson and Richard Adloff followed up their book *Empire's End in Southeast Asia* (1949) with a study of socialist and communist movements in the region (Thompson and Adloff 1950). At the same time Rupert Emerson shifted his attention from nationalist movements in Southeast Asia to US policy in the region (Emerson 1950: 484–91), and Lennox Mills became more narrowly focused on the problem of communism in Vietnam (Mills 1950: 366–78).

One of the most widely quoted books on Southeast Asia in the early 1950s, Philip Thayer's *Southeast Asia in the Coming World* (1953), consisted of a collection of papers on American policy in the region in the context of the communist threat.

There were notable exceptions to this trend;[19] but there was an unmistakable shift toward the study of political and economic issues that were seen to be of relevance to the Cold War. To a certain extent this is not surprising. As Wood explains, the subdiscipline of area studies always had a practical dimension. It grew out of the Second World War and the recognition by Allied governments of 'an alarming shortage of individuals who were seriously acquainted with the languages, cultures and topographical characteristics of the world areas in which troops had to fight and about which important political and social decisions had to be made' (Wood 1968: 401). The American Sinologist Harold Quigley wrote in 1951 that 'students of foreign areas have an obligation to the nation and the world to aid in every way possible to make their knowledge useful' (Quigley 1951: 506). However, in the case of Southeast Asian studies, the relationship between scholarly endeavour and the 'national interest' seems to have developed later than it did in the cases of Japan or the Soviet Union. Only after the spread of the Cold War to the region in 1948 did linkage between academic and foreign policy objectives become apparent.

The spread of the Cold War to Southeast Asia in the late 1940s not only changed the nature of scholarly work on the region, it set in motion a process that legitimized a geopolitical space that previously barely existed beyond the realm of scholarship. The formative phase of the regionalization of Southeast Asia gave way to the expansionary. Beginning in about 1950, the idea of Southeast Asia began to *recur* with increasing frequency in the media and in popular discourse in such a way that it quickly became widely recognized as a subregion of Asia with a distinct geographical and political profile. Non-specialists, journalists and politicians began to employ the concept with increasing frequency, and it became the basis of such important international structures as the 'Colombo Plan for Cooperative Economic Development in South and South-East Asia' (1951) and the 'Southeast Asia Treaty Organization' (SEATO) (1954). Beginning in 1950 international organizations like the United Nations Food and Agriculture Organization (UNESCO) and the World University Service began to issue reports on the region (World University Service 1951; UN, UNESCO 1952; UN, FAO 1952), as did a great variety of American national and governmental bodies, including the Public Affairs Institute (Turner 1950), the Economic Cooperation Administration (US, Economic Cooperation Administration 1951), the US Chamber of Commerce (US, Chamber of Commerce 1952) and the Mutual Security Agency (US, Mutual Security Agency 1952). But, paradoxically, as the circle of regionalizers grew larger and more diverse, so the identity of the region itself became narrower and less specifically defined. The

academic effort to create the region by identifying boundaries and making connections had also highlighted the region's plurality and variety; unquestioning acceptance by non-specialists of those boundaries and connections produced an entity with many fewer contradictions or anomalies. The concept of Southeast Asia shifted further from the academic to the popular, making it more flexible and adaptable to a variety of purposes.

This process reached an extreme at the height of the Cold War in Southeast Asia, when the region became characterized on the basis of what the West feared it might become. It was seen as a zone where poverty and political instability made it an easy target for communist propaganda and infiltration.

What is particularly noteworthy about the 'Cold War' period in the regionalization of Southeast Asia is that the common elements that were seen to unify the region, namely underdevelopment and political instability, became incorporated into the domino theory and became a core feature of it. The downtrodden peasants of Southeast Asia were not a security risk to the West simply because they were perceived to be too weak militarily to resist the forces of international communism; rather, their poverty and weakness made them highly vulnerable to the *appeal* of communism.[20]

The domino theory exerted an important influence upon the regionalization of Southeast Asia because it concentrated attention upon the political character of the region rather than its political variety. The work of Lasker, Jacoby and Firth had prepared the ground for this reductionist approach by highlighting the political and economic commonalities in the life of the typical Southeast Asian peasant. The domino theory and the scholarship associated with it took this approach one step further by imagining into the Southeast Asian political space a simplified political character that was more a reflection of Western Cold War paranoia about the appeal of communism among the poor and oppressed than it was a product of objective social scientific research. At a common level, the Southeast Asian political character was understood in the simplest of terms, the peoples of the region being seen as indifferent, weak, feeble, immature and simple. The Australian minister of external affairs, R. G. Casey, believed that the domino principle derived from an inherent inertness and indifference among the Southeast Asian peoples. 'No country can be saved from Communism unless its government and people want to be saved', he said in May 1954, a few days after the fall of Dien Bien Phu.[21] In a similar vein, John Foster Dulles said of the Southeast Asian members of SEATO: 'these fellows are so weak and feeble, one wonders if it is any good to have a treaty with them'.[22]

At the academic level, the interpretation was slightly more complex and nuanced. In 1949, G. L. Arnold wrote of three types of Southeast Asian political organizations: 'Communist', 'Fascist', and 'progressive in a Western sense' (Arnold 1949: 267). In 1950, John K. Fairbank divided the political forces in Asia into 'conservative' and 'reformist-revolutionary'

(Fairbank 1950: 106–7). Nevertheless, during this tense period, the tendency to generalize the region's identity remained strong.

In 1953 Rupert Emerson acknowledged that the countries of Southeast Asia had several political choices open to them: 'representative government', 'authoritarian' or 'communist'. But he believed that choice was constrained by the common political character of the region, which he considered to be 'revolutionary' (in the sense of 'chaotic', 'unpredictable' and 'tumultuous'), and its socio-economic profile (poor and politically immature). In these circumstances he believed that the appeal of authoritarian and communist options would be significant (Emerson 1953: 291–302).[23]

In this section we have seen how repeated recognition of the concept of Southeast Asia by a variety of individuals and organizations acted to fix the region's identity in a broad Anglo-American cultural context. The 'recurrence' phase of the regionalization process did not challenge or seek to redefine the boundaries or connections upon which the regional idea was based. Rather, it reaffirmed by means of repetition and reproduction those that had been recognized earlier. This process gave the idea of Southeast Asia what Relph would characterize as greater stability and continuity. However, in the process of gaining an increasingly durable identity, it moved beyond the realm of academia and became less specifically defined or tied to particular details. It became common property, a region in the world with an identity or 'character' open to various interpretations, stereotypes and uses. Under the influence of the Cold War, this identity was shaped by the dominant Western states and state actors to reflect the anxieties and concerns about the communist enemy that collectively were incorporated into the domino theory.

It was at this point that indigenous political actors recognized the usefulness of the Southeast Asian idea for collective political and economic objectives and began the construction of a regional organization that would allow them to utilize the idea for these purposes. In January 1959, Tunku Abdul Rahman of Malaya met with President Carlos Garcia of the Philippines to discuss the creation of a Southeast Asian-based treaty of friendship and economic cooperation. Thailand's support for the idea was secured soon afterwards, but Indonesia held aloof (Gordon 1966: 165–72; Acharya 2000: 79). In July 1961, the governments of Malaya, Thailand and the Philippines joined to form ASA with the idea that claiming the concept of Southeast Asia for an indigenous regional organization would be useful in giving additional meaning to the goal of promoting economic and social cooperation between these three quite different countries (ASA 1961, 1962). Although the organization became moribund soon afterwards as a result of Indonesian hostility and the regional tensions generated by the initiative to create a Malayan Federation, it set an important precedent for the creation of ASEAN later in the decade (Acharya 2000: 81–2).

Conclusion

ASEAN's inheritance is not the *vision* of ASEAN-10, but rather the region upon which this vision has been transposed. That region developed from the search by a relatively small group of British and American social scientists for solutions to political and economic problems common to a particular cluster of small countries in the southeastern region of Asia. The premise of the work was that in order to be successfully incorporated into the modern world, these countries first had to be systematically studied and understood. The creation of a regional structure to tie together both the countries being studied and the scholarly activity itself was in line with the academic movement toward area studies during and after the Second World War. The region's importance in the Pacific War, and then the Cold War, created an opportunity for a nexus to develop between the interests of academics and those of other regionalizers. Knowledge of the region and its languages became important, and organizations like the Rockefeller Foundation and the Carnegie Corporation acknowledged that fact by providing funds for the extension of knowledge on Southeast Asia. By the early 1950s the regionalist project was being driven more by the exigencies of the Cold War rather than by the interests of the first generation of Southeast Asian scholars. Coincidentally, the concept of Southeast Asia became incorporated into other, smaller regionalist projects, and as such became more solidly established in international organizations, government agencies and NGOs; universities adopted and utilized the concept, as did countless newspapers, news magazines, broadcast organizations and publishing houses. In almost every case, Southeast Asia became a metaphor for a collection of political and economic ideas that applied as much to the individual countries of the region as to the region itself. These included political instability, vulnerability to outside interference, economic underdevelopment, and the domino theory. With the passage of time, the precise nature of what the term was used to mean was less than the fact that it was being used for something, and that the recurrence of its usage was becoming increasingly evident.

In the beginning the Southeast Asian regionalist 'project' was designed and implemented by individuals and organizations external to the region. It involved discovering political and economic similarities between a group of quite diverse countries and encircling them within a geographical boundary. Beyond this, it involved creating structures that gave meaning to the new space. One such structure was the traditional–modern paradigm. Another was the peasant-based agricultural society and the expectation that the peasant's harsh and rudimentary connection with the land and the traditional society in which he existed both limited and defined his actions. Thus, when the Philippines, Thailand and Malaya came together to form the Association of Southeast Asia (ASA) in 1961, 'Southeast Asia' was already a meaningful concept, both politically and

spatially. The indigenization of this concept by ASA and then ASEAN appears to have given it extra power and meaning. In its recent document 'ASEAN vision 2020', ASEAN's members asserted their belief in an ideal Southeast Asia 'where *our* mountains, rivers and seas no longer divide *us* but link *us* together in friendship, cooperation and commerce' (ASEAN 2000a, emphasis added). Here the distinction between 'Southeast Asia' the place and 'ASEAN' the political organization is blurred completely.

In a broader sense, this study suggests that rather than a unilinear process, regionalization is a complex one which operates in overlapping cycles. The first stage, which might be called the foundational, sees regions conceived and then built on the basis of the identification of boundaries and connections. The increasing use of the idea or concept of the region by a variety of actors then fixes it in a broader cultural context, but also leads into a second phase, which is here called the recurrent. In this phase the regional concept becomes the property of additional regionalizers of various degrees of power and influence, who modify the concept according to their needs and interests.

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Notes

1 This understanding of regions as 'projects' rather than 'places' distinguishes them from the geographically based notion of a 'natural region'. On the latter, see Gilbert (1960: 158); Unwin (1992: 194–5).
2 On the importance of the development of 'the idea of a region and notions of "regionness"' to the regionalization process, see Hurrell (1995: 37–8).
3 The introductory chapter in Stone (1996) is helpful in demonstrating how academics can become important policy actors. Russell Fifield was the first to draw attention to the role of scholarship in the 'evolution of the regional notion of Southeast Asia'; however, he did not explore or substantiate this idea (Fifield 1984: 125).
4 The other books in the series were: Shepherd (1941); Emerson *et al.* (1942); Callis (1942); Furnivall (1942); and Lasker (1942).
5 Christian (1942) included part of China within the scope of the term. MacFadden *et al.* (1946) incorporated India, Korea and Japan as well. Mende (1955) included India, Pakistan and Ceylon.
6 For information on Heine-Geldern, see Emmerson (1984: 5–6).
7 From Volume 16, No. 1 (November 1956), the *FEQ* was renamed *The Journal of Asian Studies*.

8 Although the 'Far Eastern Bibliography' was discontinued in 1954, the classification 'Southeast Asia' continued to be used in the journal's 'Book Reviews' section.
9 There is evidence that in the first ten years of its existence, ASEAN defined the borders of Southeast Asia in a more flexible way than it did subsequently. Ceylon [Sri Lanka]'s membership was apparently encouraged (unsuccessfully) by the organization in 1967, but rejected in 1977 (Kraft 2000: 455).
10 Korhonen (1997: 348) discusses the difficulties of constructing any kind of meaningful identity around the idea of Asia as 'a geographic concept' because it 'denotes an impossibly large entity'. He says that 'All meaningful initiatives for Asian cooperation thus have to try to cut smaller pieces out of geographic Asia' but does not explore the problems involved in doing this.
11 All the countries of Southeast Asia experienced European colonization, except Thailand. For early attempts to fit Thailand into modern Southeast Asian history, see Harrison (1954: xi, 191–257) and Hall (1955: 578–612, 724–6).
12 With respect to 'island Southeast Asia', it did not include the Philippines and most of the Dutch East Indies, which were part of Douglas MacArthur's 'Southwest Pacific' command; nor did it include French Indochina, which was part of Chiang Kai-shek's 'China' command.
13 See note 11.
14 On this general theme, see Neher (1984: 130–1).
15 The Indian historian K. M. Panikkar's *The Future of South-East Asia: An Indian View* (1943) likewise placed emphasis upon decolonization as a means of securing the involvement and cooperation of Southeast Asian countries in the construction of the post-war security order (Panikkar 1943: 35). He saw the peoples of Southeast Asia as being unified by the commonality of their political aspirations and the strategic importance of the lands they inhabited.
16 In a similar vein, Vandenbosch (1946: 435) wrote that 'While the region cannot be said to be a unit from the point of view of social and economic conditions, there is nevertheless a great similarity in this respect in all the countries.'
17 There were some exceptions. Cora DuBois' *Social Forces in Southeast Asia*, for example, adhered to the pattern set by Furnivall and Landon of looking to the past for the source of a distinctive Southeast Asian identity (DuBois 1949: 61–72).
18 Following the creation of the Federation of Malaya in August 1957, only Singapore, Sarawak, Sabah, Brunei and Portuguese Timor remained colonies or dependencies of countries external to the region.
19 Throughout the 1950s Bruno Lasker continued to conduct research upon social problems in Southeast Asia, and J. S. Furnivall retained his focus on socio-economic problems in Burma and Malaya (Furnivall 1958).
20 Prototype versions of the domino theory were floated as early as 1949 by the British (Charrier 1995: 121) and 1950 by the Americans (Fifield 1975: 46). But following Eisenhower's enunciation of the domino principle in April 1954 Schulzinger (1997: 66–7) the notion of Southeast Asia as a grouping of vulnerable and interlinked polities and economies became commonly accepted.
21 R. G. Casey quoted in Harper (1955: 206).
22 Dulles, record of a telephone conversation with Carl McCardle, 31 August 1954, quoted in Ninkovich (1994: 225).
23 This notion of the simple and easily led peasant was also applied to French politics. See Ehrmann (1952: 41) and Wright (1955: 85). An important difference, however, was that whereas the French peasant was seen to represent one strand of the complex political fabric of France, his Southeast Asian relative was regarded as the basic unit of Southeast Asia political identity.

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